ALLEN DULLES WAS A GRAY-HAIRED, PIPE-SMOKING VETERAN of US espionage and a holdover from the Eisenhower administration. Director of the CIA, he first presented his plan for the invasion of Cuba to Kennedy on January 28, one week after the inauguration.

The CIA deputy director for plans, Richard M. Bissell, the former administrator of the Marshall Plan in postwar Germany, was the principal author of the plan, which proposed to land on Cuba hundreds of guerrilla fighters recruited from the ranks of Cuban exiles and trained in CIA camps in Guatemala. Bissell recommended the establishment of a beachhead on Cuban territory with access to the sea and an airstrip that could serve as a base of operations for the future Cuban government. He hoped that the invasion would inspire a popular uprising against Castro's regime but did not count on that. Bissell envisioned the next stage of the operation as "an overt, open US initiative to institute a military occupation of the island by a composite OAS [Organization of American States] force in order to put a stop to the civil war."[11]

The last part of the plan made some of Kennedy's advisers nervous. General Lyman Lemnitzer, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, suggested that the force of some six to eight thousand men currently in training was inadequate to achieve the goal, given the Castro government's continuing military buildup. He suggested that "final planning will have to include agreed plans for providing additional support for the Cuban force—presumably such support to be US." Lemnitzer knew that the American military would have to intervene and wanted clarity on the matter. Secretary of State Dean Rusk had different concerns, predicting an international backlash against the invasion. His people foresaw "grave political dangers to our position throughout the Western hemisphere in any overt military action not authorized and supported by the Organization of American States."

Kennedy sent his advisers back to the drawing board. The Defense Department was ordered to make a military assessment of the operation and the State Department to work on getting the Latin American countries on board. It was "agreed that the United States must make entirely clear that its position with respect to the Cuban Government is currently governed by its firm opposition to Communist penetration of the American Republics, and